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RAAD VAN BEHEER
HOUDEN VAN HONDEN

What is your general appreciation of the proposal?

The Dutch Kennel Club “Raad van Beheer” fully agrees with the stated principles for arriving at EU guidelines for the welfare of dogs and cats. In recent years we have regularly indicated that we would like to have identical European regulations. Dutch breeders of pedigree dogs who are fully committed to responsible breeding have been experiencing 'unfair competition' from foreign breeders and trade of dogs for decades.

The problems that dogs bred abroad and imported here experience in terms of health, welfare and behavior are evident. We are therefore pleased that there is now a proposal for overarching, identical and equivalent rules for all EU countries. This benefits the welfare of dogs in Europe.

Welfare and traceability

The Dutch Kennel Club is a strong supporter of good I&R for both dogs and cats. These EU rules are a combination of I&R and animal welfare. In the Netherlands, these decisions are separated from each other. It is good if this is applied EU-wide; but there is a chance that the NL rules are different. What happens then?

Enforcement and current Dutch regulations

Enforcement in the Netherlands is already a challenge. We would like to strongly warn against strict rules that are then only observed and/or enforced by part of the Union. That would strive beyond the purpose of a level playing field.

In any case, it is important that these EU rules do not result in additional administrative tasks for chippers, breeders and dog owners. That now seems to be the case.

The intention is for the databases of the different EU countries to connect with each other. That is a necessity to make control possible. Since we have been introducing such a system in the Netherlands for years, it is important that no new investments are required for large-scale adjustments to the current portals.

Docking

Docking is only allowed if there is medical necessity. How does this fit in with the current NL rules (incl. proposed Order in Council)?

Information obligation upon sale

It's good that breeders/sellers are required to inform buyers about what it means to take a dog into their home. Responsible pedigree breeders have been doing this for years with great success. The number of pedigree dogs in shelters is therefore virtually zero.

Determine professional/commercial breeders

The Dutch Kennel Club is also concerned about the limits set in numbers to determine whether or not somebody is breeding commercial/professional. It is not clear where these numbers come from and the impact can be very significant. The limit of three bitches (where it is only important if they are bred and in what frequency) and a total of two or

fewer litters per calendar year means that suddenly more Dutch pedigree breeders are above this limit. For pedigree breeders, this would mean a doubling of the number of breeders (200 to 400) subject to these regulations compared to the guideline of 20 puppies / 4 litters per year.

If we assume that pedigree breeding accounts for approximately one third of Dutch breeding, this would have an enormous impact on Dutch breeding and the government that must monitor these institutions. Breeders must also ensure an annual visit by the veterinarian to their breeding facility/home, again the impact is significant, while the availability of veterinary services is currently already under pressure in the Netherlands.

Deployment of professional chippers / competent authority
Only veterinarians (and their assistants) should still be allowed to place and register chips. Now the specially trained Dutch Kennel Club employees do this in the Netherlands for the 32,000 pedigree puppies that are born annually. Our chippers are the most experienced and skilled chippers in the Netherlands who perform the most chipping procedures, more than any veterinarian and veterinary practice. This ensures high quality, a comprehensive process of identification and registration and a 100% check of all litters, puppies and locations, including DNA collection for parentage control. For the Dutch Kennel Club this is an extremely important, maybe even exclusive condition to give meaning to their successful and responsible breeding policy. It is important that our chippers have a 'competent authority'.

Cage sizes (location control)
The EU also proposes other cage sizes than those described in the old HKB. Although current Dutch regulations no longer describe cage sizes, the HKB are still a widely used guideline. The proposed sizes are larger and mean that breeders will have to adapt the cages and make investments that will have to be checked again. The Dutch Kennel Club applies rules for location control and checks and registers by means of a form (see attachment).

The mandatory training of breeders is something that the Dutch Kennel Club agrees on. In the Netherlands we of course already have the professional competence requirement for commercial breeders. The Dutch Kennel Club is concerned about the impact of this obligation if the limit is set at 3 litters per calendar year.

Internet
The Dutch Kennel Club is strongly in favor of the regulation of internet offers for dogs and cats. As the EU proposes, this provides insight into the origin of the puppies and provides immediate insight into whether the I&R conditions have been met. The consumer is often unfamiliar with the origin of his/her new dog. By making this clear in advance, the consumer is probably better able to think about this carefully. When the consumer is already at the breeder or trader and receives the young animal in his/her hands, it is often no longer possible to make a realistic and good choice. The use of a 'verification system' that only allows registered breeders to advertise is a strict condition.

Breeding age
The Dutch Kennel Club already has good rules for the use of animals in breeding for a long time. For example, we have a minimum age and maximum age for the bitch, minimum period between litters and combinations that are prohibited on the basis of inbreeding. There are significant differences in ages in the proposed regulations, which we do not support based on experience and scientific substantiation.

• The EU now sets an age limit of 18 months for the bitch (the Dutch Kennel Club maintains 16 months). Small dogs in particular reach maturity sooner and can therefore also be mated during the second heat cycle (after 16 months). The 18 months means that small dogs that are physically and mentally suitable for breeding at an early age may only be used for breeding much later (during the next heat cycle).
• The Dutch Kennel Club has increased the maximum age of the bitch (72 months for 1st mating, 108 months for last mating). Precisely for the sake of healthy breeding, it is good to use fit older dogs for breeding, as they have proven themselves to grow up and remain healthy. Every dog must be fit for a pregnancy and younger dogs cannot be fit either. It is difficult for the vet to prove that a dog is healthy for breeding. What should be done about this? Is listening to the heart and lungs (general examination) sufficient? Or should an ultrasound be done to check the uterus, X-rays to check the joints and also an extensive blood test for kidney, heart and liver function? It always remains the breeder's responsibility to breed the bitch and to request veterinary guidance.

Age separation of animals
It is good that there is a general EU rule on separating the young animal from the mother. The age at which a puppy may leave the litter has been increased in the EU proposal, compared to Dutch legislation, to 8 weeks. The Dutch Kennel Club is not in favor of this. For socialization it is good if puppies of certain breeds or from large litters can go to their new owners at 7 weeks. This provides other opportunities for socialization than with the breeder. If the limit remains at 7 weeks, it is always possible to release the puppies to the new owner at 8 weeks or later, but this can be determined based on the needs of the bitch and the puppies.

Inbreeding limitation & registration of parents & parentage verification
At least, the limitation of inbreeding that the EU proposes misses is the fact that a bitch may not be mated by her brother or by her half-brother. These are omissions that still need to be corrected in our opinion.

In addition, it is important that checks can only be carried out when the parent animals are registered in the I&R databases. That is now not the case. As far as the Dutch Kennel Club is concerned, enforcement can only be done properly if the lineage is also proven trough DNA.

Aantal nesten per periode
De aangegeven maximum van 3 nesten per 2 jaar met daaropvolgend minimaal een jaar reproductierust is een vergelijking van de Nederlandse regel van maximaal 1 nest per jaar. De Nederlandse regel is wat betreft de Raad van Beheer simpeler en duidelijker en daarmee

beter uitvoerbaar. Er zijn ons geen wetenschappelijke studies bekend die de nieuwe regel ondersteunen ten voordele van de bestande Nederlandse regels.

Care
The Annex to the regulation then provides very clear guidelines about housing and care. The Dutch Kennel Club does not always understand where the guidelines come from. Dogs are predators and are therefore used to eating irregularly. The requirement to eat twice a day is not the best feeding regimen for all dogs. It is better to look at the results of the feeding sessions, where for example, a minimum and maximum Body Condition Score can be maintained.

Number of litters per period
The stated maximum of 3 litters per 2 years with a subsequent minimum of one year of reproductive rest is a comparison of the Dutch rule of a maximum of 1 litter per year. As far as the Dutch Kennel Club is concerned, the Dutch rule is easier and clearer and therefore more feasible. We are not aware of any scientific studies that support the new rule in favor of the existing Dutch rule.

Transportation
The Dutch Kennel Club is a strong supporter of better rules for the transport of dogs. If the rules are properly embedded and adhered throughout the EU, this can improve the welfare and health of dogs, in which the public health is also safer because the risk of diseases being introduced is reduced.

The Dutch Kennel Club is pleased that the rules do not apply to owners who want to travel with their dog. The Dutch Kennel Club is concerned about the general wording that the rules only apply to transport in relation to an economic activity.

Transport pedigree dogs before 12/15 weeks
We are well aware that keeping dogs also entails risks. In our opinion, a dog has the right to a good start with the breeder, good upbringing, good health care and protection against parasites, viruses and other pathogens. After all, it is quite a responsibility to take a dog into your home.

It is evident that the Netherlands is trying to prevent the introduction of diseases that do not occur here. Vaccinations have clearly proven over the years that they can reduce risks. Rabies is such a dangerous disease for humans and animals. Fortunately, there are several vaccines available. Especially in the case of pedigree dogs with an FCI pedigree, it is visible and verifiable (microtransponder) who the parents are. This also makes it easy to check the vaccinations of the parent.

It would be good if well-intentioned and responsible breeders could import young dogs and ensure that the dog is better socialized. It is important for dogs that good socialization and education takes place in the period up to 12 weeks. In this first phase of life, a puppy must be able to get the right experiences that are important for the rest of its life.

It is therefore important that dogs come to their new owners at a young age (from at least 7 weeks) so that they can get used to the people and the environment that they will encounter the rest of their lives.

We therefore advocate an exemption for dogs with an FCI pedigree whose mother has been correctly vaccinated, the puppies have not been in contact with other animals and have remained with the mother until at least 7 weeks. This exception is possible by having the owner declare that the puppy has not come into contact with wild animals of species susceptible to rabies from birth until the moment of (non-commercial) transport. Ultimately, we want to be able to select for the right characteristics of the parent animals. It is therefore extremely important that animals can be brought from abroad at a young age. They can grow up here in a well-socialized and controlled manner and, if suitable, can also be used for Dutch breeding of pedigree dogs.

Temperature transport
The indicated temperature range for transporting dogs is very narrow, it is set between 20-25 degrees Celsius. The Dutch Kennel Club does not fully understand where this very narrow bandwidth comes from, precisely because the Annex on well-being maintains an indoor temperature between 10 and 26 degrees Celsius.

Surface
It is also striking that the Annex to the Regulations does not mention a minimum surface area for the transport of dogs. This seems like an omission. Current inspections already show that the rogue dog trade often uses crates that are too small and stacked and can seriously harm the welfare of the dogs. The Dutch Kennel Club wonders whether the other rules can sufficiently guarantee that the dogs are given sufficient space

In your opinion, is the proposal feasible?
Some of the proposed regulations have already been introduced in the Netherlands. A number of rules are already being applied in a stricter form in the Netherlands. A number of rules have been introduced in a less strict form with clearly assignable (scientific) substantiation by the sector in the Netherlands in recent years. We do not always see adjustments as desirable or feasible.

In addition, the impact of the legislation largely depends on good enforcement of the rules. We have experienced in recent years that this is seriously lacking in the Netherlands. The Dutch Kennel Club believes that this is a condition for the feasibility of the proposed rules. The regulations must ensure that rogue breeders and traders disappear and stop their activities. Enforcement is necessary for this.

What (financial) impact does the proposal have on your sector?

Dutch Kennel Club
- Abolition of chipping of pedigree dogs by the Dutch Kennel Club as part of the total chain has an enormous impact on us as an ANBI organization. The right to exist as a social

organization is at stake.
- IT adjustments for portals. Large, depending on necessary adjustments and investments.

Breeders
- Requirements for living areas differ, which may require investments.
- Requirements regarding the deployment of veterinarians will cost more money. Veterinary fees have risen in recent years, making this almost unaffordable. More (mandatory) deployment of veterinarians will increase costs.

What do you think are the most positive aspects of this proposal and why?

1) The same rules throughout the EU; that ensures a level playing field for breeders of pedigree and non-pedigree dogs.

2) Reduce the 15-week rule to 12 weeks; This means that puppies can be sent from abroad to their new owners sooner. This benefits socialization and bonding. The Dutch Kennel Club continues to emphasize that an exception should be possible for pedigree dogs, as this also applies to other EU countries.

3) That Dutch regulations may be stricter than EU regulations

What do you think are the negative aspects of this proposal and why?

1) chipping and registration only by veterinarians; For the Dutch Kennel Club, identification by our chippers is an indispensable link in the chain of responsible breeding of pedigree dogs.

2) When registering, there is still no mandatory registration of mother dog (+ father dog), which means that inspection of breeding and ownership of mother dog cannot be checked.

3) new (sometimes stricter) rules for breeders/owners; This can cause that breeders of pedigree dogs breed less and that potential puppy buyers are more likely to end up with (unscrupulous) breeders and traders.

What do you think should be the focus of Dutch efforts on this proposal?

According to the Dutch Kennel Club, the four focus points are:

1. Enforcement: this must be feasible. We see that this is already a challenge in the Netherlands. How are we going to arrange this at European level? Example: by assuming breeders with 3 or more litters in the proposed regulations, the group of 'professional breeders' for pedigree dogs in the Netherlands is already doubled (assuming now 4 or more litters).

2. Attention to socialization and behavior by the breeder: a dog that is imported and has suffered behavioral problems during this first period with the breeder and during transport

will carry this with it throughout its further life. Behavior is present 24 hours a day. (See also Bureau Beke Report, 'as sick as a dog'.

3. Responsible ownership. The role of the owner is underexposed in this proposal. These regulations should provide a better start for central policy for consumers.

4. Maintaining the good NL rules; the EU rules should not become stricter or deviate from them. The standards/requirements within NL are already high.

Are there any other matters regarding the proposal that you would like to point out that have not yet been mentioned above?
See also point 3 under focus: The Dutch Kennel Club misses rules for consumers who knowingly continue to buy dogs from illegal breeders/sellers. It would be a great support to this legislation if appropriate legislation were put in place to close the cycle.